Appendix Case Study: Swinburne Guru Consulting Coaching Processes

Swinburne Guru Consulting (SGC) is a small business in Hawthorn. Established in January 2012, it operates from an office in the Hawthorn area. Emily Sodapop owns the business and has four permanent employees. Her business coaches individuals and organisations in teamwork, leadership, and personal performance coaching. The coaching is conducted by Emily and a team of coaches who work on a session-by-session basis. The other coaches operate as subcontractors.

SGC started as a home-based business with Emily as the sole operator. Originally, most of Emily's work came from recommendations from other consulting agencies and associates. Some of her work also came through her LinkedIn account or other sources. The amount of work grew, so Emily could not handle it alone. She sometimes had to recruit other coaches to take on or help her with some of the work. Seeing an opportunity, the Swinburne Guru Consulting business began, and it has blossomed ever since. A website and a Facebook presence were created. The business has grown to the point that she now provides work to other coaches regularly. There is roughly a 50:50 split between one-to-one work, where a coach deals with one person at a time, and group sessions, where a company might, for example, run a teamwork workshop for several of its employees simultaneously.

Over time, Emily hired a full-time receptionist and personal assistant. A part-time bookkeeper manages the accounts. Later, she hired a "coaching administrator" on a part-time basis. His job was coordinating the work required among clients and coaches when coaching requests came in. A client relations manager deals directly with clients and coaches in the organisation and follow-up of coaching sessions.

SGC has a basic website that describes the business and its coaching services, a page with the main people and coaches involved with SGC, testimonials from happy clients and a "Contact us" page for enquiries. The website is not the main source of attracting business and possibly lacks the polish and finesse that one would expect from a professional quality website.

The challenge

While in the past, business processes tended to change only slowly over time, Emily and her management team firmly hold that SGC must be able to adapt and improve their processes more rapidly over time. The terms "agile" and "agile development" have now become common terminology within the management team to reflect the idea that the organisation must rapidly adapt as needed to any future changes. However, they have been aware that making changes in the past has been difficult. An external consultant was hired to investigate their corporate culture and the issues mentioned above were presented. Emily and her management team is absorbing the lessons and considering what needs to be done.

One lesson is that they have already learned is that they need to improve business operational efficiency through clear, effective and well-documented processes to assist the business with smooth operations. Business process models must be able to be easily updated to reflect the current operations and future requirements and should be created in

a format that facilitates scalability to allow for these future changes. However, SGC cannot afford to maintain a full-time process management team, and it is considered very important that an "average" employee, with relatively little training, should eventually be able to maintain and adapt business process models to reflect current and future needs.

Project requirements and scope

The following objectives were decided upon in a series of meetings with senior management:

- Creating process mapping descriptions using Business Process Modelling Notation (BPMN).
- A small number of key processes to be developed and mapped out.
- Review these processes and make suggestions for possible improvements to improve efficiency.

As a trial, the current coaching management processes (such as handling customer enquiries, searching for coaches, scheduling, verifying, payment and managing blacklist) are modelled. Any issues with the processes need to be highlighted, and suggestions for improvement should be proposed. New process models representing the desired process should be developed as needed.

Current Coaching Management Process Description

Clients call the company to request a personal tutor or coach to develop some particular skill or ability. The company engages a suitable tutor or coach on behalf of the client and handles all the accounting for the relationship for a fee. This is called an assignment.

The assignment process starts when the receptionist, Linda, receives a communication from a potential client by phone, in person or email requesting coaching assistance. The receptionist creates an assignment which begins the process. The receptionist requires personal information from the client such as name and address, contact details and the location(s) where the coaching is required by the client, plus information about the client's availability and reasons why they require a coach. The receptionist will check if the client has called previously, in which case much of this information will already be held, but still requires confirmation. When the information is complete, the receptionist submits the request. For the clients forwarded by Emily's LinkedIn account or other sources, such as Emily's friends or other businesses, after Emily reviews, she will forward them to the receptionist to record details. The process will be the same as other clients, but some of them may receive some discounts.

The request is received by the coaching specialist, Ahmed, who is familiar with the coaches and what they do but, if needed, can also search the company database to find appropriate coaches for specific skills. There may be several coaches for a particular skill(s). For example, client Mary may wish to improve her public speaking skills and so Ahmed, the coaching specialist, tries to find the most appropriate public speaking coach. Once located, the assignment needs to be scheduled. Coaches have a variety of commitments at any one time so the scheduler contacts the coach to arrange the most appropriate time. Madeleine, the client relations officer, acts as the scheduler and will contact the client to confirm the

assignment, the scheduled time and costs. Sometimes when the client is contacted, they may cancel the coaching rather than go ahead. If the recommended coach is unavailable at the same time as the client, the scheduler passes the assignment back to the coaching specialist to find another coach.

If the client requests a skill for which no coach is available, instead of cancelling the assignment, and with the client's consent, the specialist advertises for a coach with that skill. The coaching specialist will interview the applicants to find a suitable coach. If no suitable coach is found within 2 weeks after the advertisement, the coaching specialist informs the client the assignment is cancelled. Otherwise, they pass a new recommendation onto the scheduler.

The verifier's role is to contact the coach and client shortly before coaching is scheduled to begin as a reminder and confirmation of the assignment. Madeleine usually does the verification process, but if she is too busy, she will ask Ahmed or Linda to do this. Once the coach and client both confirm the assignment, the coaching sessions proceed.

If the client fails to confirm, the assignment is cancelled and the coach/tutor is contacted about the cancellation. If the coach fails to confirm, the company will contact the client and offer a new time with the same coach, find a new coach or allow them to cancel the coaching. Ahmed may ask Linda or Emily to make contact if he is too busy.

After a coaching assignment is completed, Madeleine, as the client relations officer, follows up with the client and the coach to determine how satisfied the client and coach or tutor are with the assignment. Once completed questionnaires from both the coach and client have been received, Madeleine compiles a report.

After completing an assignment, the bookkeeper compiles an invoice and sends it to the client. The detailed amounts will be recorded in the invoices for the clients who receive discounts. This will not impact Coach payments. In the meantime, the coach sends an invoice to the company bookkeeper. The bookkeeper must have the customer's payment and the coach's invoice before the coach can be paid. If 30 days have elapsed after the bookkeeper has sent the invoice to the client, and no payment is received, the bookkeeper writes to the customer to remind them of the payment. If, after 90 days, payment has still not been received, the bookkeeper passes the unpaid invoice to the manager, who writes to the customer. The unpaid debt is sold to a debt collection agency and the client is blacklisted.

Once payment has been received from the client, the coach has been paid and the client relations officer has compiled the satisfaction survey, the assignment is considered complete.